

Getting It Right ONCE AGAIN

Despite a modest track record in office, Chouhan's common touch pays dividends



SHIVRAJ SINGH
CHOUHAN

PANKAJ TIWARI

| By Ambresh Mishra |

Only once in the last 25 years has an assembly election failed to change the face of the Government in Madhya Pradesh when Digvijay Singh, who first became the chief minister in the 1993 elections, won a resounding victory five years later. With 144 of a total of 230 seats, Madhya Pradesh Chief Minister Shivraj Singh Chouhan has not only led the BJP to an impressive victory in the just-concluded polls, but it is the first time that the party has managed to win back-to-back Assembly elections in the state. As trends became available within the first hour of counting on December 8, the writing for

the Congress was on the wall. It was facing another rout with the BJP having pulled ahead of the pack. It didn't matter that the party's tally was 29 less than what it won five years ago; or even that the Congress had almost doubled its tally to 70 this time. For every seat that the Congress won, the BJP got two in its winning kitty.

The BJP, which has little to cheer about the assembly elections, should perhaps take a leaf out of Chouhan's campaign manual. With a modest track record as an administrator and little to show by way of achievements, the soft-spoken agriculturist of humble means employed